1.4 Education and Literacy

Why do you read? Probably for fun or to learn new things. Colonial children mostly learned to read so they could understand the Bible.

MAIN IDEA Education and literacy were important to New England colonists and had a major impact on the region's economic and social development.

AMERICAN PLACES

Harvard University, Cambridge, Massachusetts

Harvard began as a private college founded along the Charles River in 1636 to educate ministers of the church. It is called "Harvard" after John Harvard, from England, who left a gift of 779 English pounds and 400 books to the college. Increase Mather and John Sassamon, whom you have already read about, were both students there. Mather later served as the college's president from 1692 to 1701. The student housing shown here opened in 1931.



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A NEW ENGLAND EDUCATION

New Englanders believed people needed to be able to read so they could learn about God. They set up schools that focused on the Bible, religious study, and texts that taught moral behavior. In the 1640s, the Massachusetts legislature established **common schools**, the colonial name for elementary schools, and secondary schools called Latin grammar schools. Connecticut and other colonies followed with similar legislation. Eventually, more people in New England were able to read than in any other colony.

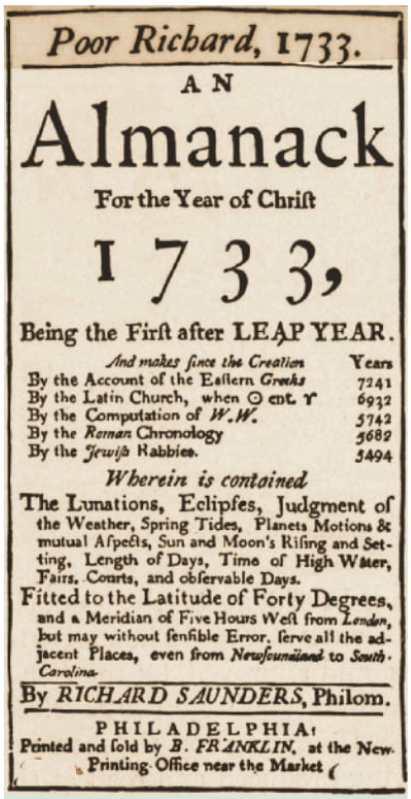
Early education also involved teaching children skills that would help them thrive in their community. For many colonial boys, this meant becoming an **apprentice**. An apprentice lived with a master craftsman for a set number of years in order to learn a trade, such as butchering, baking, or carpentry. Girls, on the other hand, often stayed with their mothers to learn cooking, sewing, and other skills necessary to manage a household.

Communities established colleges for older students. The Puritans founded Harvard College in Massachusetts in 1636 and Yale College in Connecticut in 1701. Harvard and Yale joined William and Mary College in Virginia to make up the only three colleges in the colonies. All three have grown into modern universities that offer a wide range of subjects and the chance to earn many different degrees. Most of the graduates of colonial colleges became members of the clergy. None, however, were women. Colonial colleges only admitted men.

NEWSPAPERS AND BOOKS

The rising rate of literacy throughout the colonies created a big demand for newspapers and books. Starting in 1704, newspapers popped up in Boston, Philadelphia, New York, and Charleston. These early newspapers focused on European events and politics. They helped colonists feel less separated from faraway Europe and more connected to England.

The general reading tastes of colonial people ranged across many subjects, but readers especially enjoyed topics unique to the American experience. In New England, books about being captured by Native Americans attracted interest. One of the most popular of these was by **Mary Rowlandson**. In her account, she describes being taken prisoner with her three children during King Philip's War. The Native Americans who had captured her then released her for 20 pounds' ransom. After her husband, a Puritan minister, died, Rowlandson moved to Boston and wrote the story for which she is famous.



Poor Richard, 1733.
AN
Almanack
For the Year of Chriſt
1733,
Being the Firſt after LEAP YEAR.
And makes ſince the Creation Years
By the Account of the Eaſtern Greeks 7241
By the Latin Church, when ⊙ ent. ♈ 6932
By the Computation of W.W. 5742
By the Roman Chronology 5682
By the Jewiſh Rabbies. 5494
Wherein is contained
The Lunations, Eclipſes, Judgment of the Weather, Spring Tides, Planets Motions & mutual Aſpects, Sun and Moon's Riſing and Setting, Length of Days, Time of High Water, Fairs, Courts, and obſervable Days.
Fitted to the Latitude of Forty Degrees, and a Meridian of Five Hours Weſt from London, but may without ſenſible Error, ſerve all the adjacent Places, even from Newfoundland to South-Carolina.
By RICHARD SAUNDERS, Philom.
PHILADELPHIA:
Printed and ſold by B. FRANKLIN, at the New-Printing-Office near the Market.

Poor Richard's Almanack
Ben Franklin created the almanac under the name Richard Saunders, but he credited himself as the volume's printer.

Another favorite genre, the almanac, stuffed many types of useful information together in one volume. *Poor Richard's Almanack*, published by **Benjamin Franklin**, proved a best seller. It mixed calendars, information about the weather and planting, medical advice, and witty proverbs, such as "Fish and visitors stink after three days." Also around this time, writers began to compose the first histories of their lives in the colonies. Meanwhile, to the south, life was very different—particularly for African slaves.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What types of schools did colonial New Englanders establish?
2. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** What role did religion play in the importance of education in New England?
3. **MAKE GENERALIZATIONS** Why would a newspaper's emphasis on European events and politics be helpful to colonial merchants?

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